

LECHAT'CHILAH ARIBER IN FUNDRAISING?

Dear Editor,

I have been following Rabbi Brod's fundraising column in each issue of Compass, and have gained valuable tips and helpful insight. That being said, I wonder whether his rigid, "square" modus operandi is really true to the ethos of shlichus. The Rebbe encouraged and empowered us to go lechat'chilah ariber, to stretch ourselves in every which way to do more and yet more, regardless of whether it makes sense in gidrei olam hazeh. Following such structured "rules" seems to box us in and limit our ability to do that. The eltere shluchim who blazed the trail of shlichus as we know it today did so without following any of these rules, and they accomplished far more than most of us do. I would love to see a fundraising article that doesn't talk about leads, prospects, cultivation, the ask, etc., and doesn't tell me that I need to be tied down to a calendar to be a successful shliach.

*Thanks,
M. D.*

P.S. The above is not specific to Rabbi Brod; all fundraising coaches seem to operate in a similarly rigid fashion.

Response by Rabbi Yisroel Brod, Kfar Chabad, Eretz Yisroel

► WHILE ON SHLICHUS in Teaneck, New Jersey, we once considered initiating a capital campaign with the goal of purchasing a building and doing major renovations, which would entail major expenses. When I wrote to the Rebbe about this, the Rebbe replied:

"באם יש סיכויים טובים על פי טבע להשיג האמצעים, להתעניין בהנ"ל."

To me the message was very clear. The Rebbe was giving me a clear directive to do what is known in the professional world as market research or feasibility study—to study to find out whether or not we actually have the *sikuyim tovim al pi teva*. After we analyzed the idea objectively (as objective as you can possibly be when you really want to buy *that* building), we realized it was not within our reach, and we needed to let go of that dream. Eventually, we found the right building at the right price.

Years later I came upon another very interesting letter from the Rebbe on the importance of creating a budget. In this letter, the Rebbe writes that it is impossible to run an organization properly if you do not have a budget.

Over years of witnessing the approaches of hundreds of shlichim, I have seen that those who have taken their organization to a level of professionalism (including the items you included in your question, plus more) actually see more success than those who do not want to begin this process, and instead continue to rely on miracles.

Are there exceptions to this rule? Of course. However, they are the exceptions and not the rule.

When a shliach sits in a full-day seminar and listens to one session after another on disclosure, accountability, transparency, integrity, budgeting, and so on, sooner

or later he will jump up and express his disagreement to everything that is being said. He is strongly convinced that these ideas do not fit well with all that Chassidus teaches us about *ein od milvado*, and certainly not with *lechat'chilah* ariber.

Everything that happens is *behashgachah* pratis. I recently came across an amazing letter from the Rebbe to the *hanhalah* of Yeshivas Tomchei Temimim Lubavitch in Montreal, Canada about *lechat'chilah* ariber in fundraising. Here is the relevant paragraph:

ובנוגע להפרטים, הנה במה שדברנו באסיפתם על דבר הדפיציט של הישיבה, כבר אמרתי להם בשיחתנו פה, אשר עד עתה ניסו באופן של צמצום, היינו לכוון את ההוצאה על פי ההכנסה, ומהראוי שעתה ינסו באופן ההפכי, היינו להשתדל בהגדלת ההכנסה כפי ההוצאה שצריכה להיות. ובפרט על פי פתגם כ"ק אדמו"ר מהר"ש שמוסר כ"ק מו"ח אדמו"ר בשם כ"ק אדמו"ר אביו: די וועלט זאגט, אז מ'קאן נישט ארונטער דארף מען אריבער, און איך זאג, אז מ'דארף לכתחילה אריבער בתוקף המתאים.

ממכתב ט"ז אלול תשי"א
(אגרות קודש ח"ד ע' תעז ואילך)

You write that during the meeting you discussed what to do about the yeshiva's deficit.

When you were here, I told you that your current approach is to limit your expenses based on your revenue. I would recommend trying the opposite approach, namely, to try to increase your revenue based

on what your expenses should be. This is especially appropriate when bearing in mind the Rebbe Maharash's adage, transmitted by my father-in-law, the [Friediker] Rebbe, in the name of his father, the Rebbe [Rashab]: "Everyone else says that if you can't accomplish through thinking small, think big. However, I say that you should start off by thinking big," along with the appropriate resoluteness.

Letter dated 15 Elul, 5711

(Igros Kodesh, vol. 4, pp. 477-478)

In this letter, the Rebbe defines *lechat'chilah* ariber as creating a budget of what you really need and then working to increase your income to reach that goal.

Wow! Here we have a clear directive from the Rebbe as to how to operate. You cannot know what your expenses really should be (*kefi hahotza'ah shetzrichah lihiyos*) if you do not create an annual budget with proper thought, planning, analysis of past expenses, and so on. Once that is accomplished, the next step is to increase your income (*lehishtadel behagdalah hachnasah*) to meet that budget.

Ever since the Rebbe spoke the famous sichah of Chof-Ches Nissan 5751 and used the words *oros detohu bekeilim detikkun*, I felt that this phrase encapsulates the correct approach a shliach should adopt. Creating a budget and seeing how much

you truly need, not just to get by but to accomplish the work you really need to do seems to be *oros detohu*. However, when done in a professional manner, these *oros* are contained in *keilim detikkun*. Now, this letter clearly demonstrates that this methodology is part of what it means to go *lechat'chilah* ariber.

There have been answers from the Rebbe to shlichim advising them to go *lechat'chilah* ariber in a very literal way, and there have been answers that *lechat'chilah* ariber should not be followed in a literal sense.

Most likely, those who are inclined to work in a way of *lechat'chilah* ariber and with *oros detohu* will continue doing so, and those who feel that it is important to work with *keilim detikkun* and *be'ofen hamiskabel* will be happy to find encouragement from the Rebbe's letter.

One final thought: We are charged with the mission of changing the world not through disrupting it but through elevating and transforming it. This would suggest that the only way to accomplish this is through implementing the teachings of professional fundraising and using them for the highest level of elevating and purifying the world. 🌟

► Feel free to share your comments and thoughts on this letter:
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